



For Staff

Signs of Grooming

Recognising and responding when an adult or older young person builds a relationship with a student in order to abuse or exploit them, online or offline

Content Warning

This guide covers grooming for sexual abuse, exploitation and radicalisation, including by adults in positions of trust.

This is reference guidance, not a training course. Use it to check how to respond, or to prepare for a conversation. It does not replace the school's safeguarding training, policy or the DSL's advice on a specific case.

It contains descriptions of how children are groomed online and offline, including by people who work with children, and references to sexual abuse, sexual images and exploitation (without graphic detail). Some of it may be difficult to read, particularly if it connects with your own experience or that of someone close to you.

- You can read it in sections, take a break, or step away at any point.
- If this raises something personal, you can speak in confidence to your line manager, a senior colleague you trust, or the school's Employee Assistance Programme, if it has one, or **Education Support** (free, confidential, 24/7 on 08000 562 561).
- If you have a question about how this guidance applies to a situation you are dealing with, speak to your school's Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL).

If reading this makes you worried about a child now, do not wait until you have finished reading: speak to the DSL or a deputy straight away. If a child is in immediate danger, call 999.

Immediate danger or possible risk to life: call 999 when it is needed, stay with the child, and summon the DSL or a deputy. Don't delay action to work through the steps. The 90-second Pause is for once immediate safety is secured, to stop an impulsive or investigative response. **Go to the Quick Reference Card.**

Why This Matters

Grooming is how much abuse and exploitation begins: someone builds a child's trust, and a position of power over them, in preparation for harm. 44 UK police forces recorded **7,263 offences of sexual communication with a child in the most recent year reported**; where forces could be compared, that is almost double the number in 2017/18, the first year of the offence ([NSPCC, November 2025](#)).

KCSIE 2026 describes sexual abuse as including "grooming a child in preparation for abuse", online as well as offline (paragraph 28), and lists "adults posing as children or young adults with the intention to groom or exploit them for sexual, criminal, financial or other purposes" among the contact risks of online safety (paragraph 165). Grooming rarely announces itself: staff who notice small changes, and pass them on, are often the first line of protection.

Scenario Overview

A Year 9 student has a new, older "friend" she met through an online game, who calls himself her mentor. He sends her gaming credit and gifts, tells her she is more mature than people her age, and asks her to keep their chats secret. She has become withdrawn from her friends and protective of her phone.

What to Keep in Mind

- **Grooming is a process** of small steps that each look harmless. **A pattern can help explain what is happening, but you don't need to wait for it to happen again before reporting a concern.** A request for images, a planned meeting or a threat needs action straight away.
- The student **may not see herself as a victim**, and may defend or protect the person. That is part of how grooming works, not a sign that all is well.
- **Never alert or confront the suspected groomer**, online or in person.
- Groomers can be **strangers or people the child knows**, including staff, volunteers and other young people. Grooming can lead to **sexual abuse, criminal exploitation or radicalisation**; the DSL decides the pathway.

How RESPOND Works in This Scenario

RESPOND is powered by **ACT: Active Intervention** (inaction is not neutral: grooming depends on adults not joining up the signs), **Contextual Safeguarding** (grooming happens in games, apps, clubs, neighbourhoods and peer groups, beyond the family) and **Trauma-Informed Practice** (safety before emotion before thinking; the child may feel loyal, ashamed or afraid). The steps are taught in order but work as a **helix**: see *The RESPOND Helix* section.

Step	RESPOND tool	In this scenario
● Recognise	4 Ps Context Scan; Escalation of Unseen Harm	Gifts, secrecy, an older "special" friend, a move to private apps
● Engage	TED questions; the disclosure script; 4Ds, if it is safe to do so	Stay warm; don't criticise the person or ask "why"
● Support	Safety check first; "Your calm is contagious"	Is a meeting planned? Have images been asked for? Today and tonight
● Pause	90-second grounding; Three Lenses (Risk, Rights, Resources)	Don't alert the groomer, search the phone, or tell her to delete or block today
● Offer	Model alternatives; if in doubt, N before O	What safe adults do and don't do; she is not in trouble
● Notify	DSL, as soon as is practicably possible; immediately if there is immediate risk; 999 for immediate danger	Same day; now if a meeting or images are involved. Concerns about staff go to the headteacher
● Document	GOLD standard	Her words, the gifts, the secrecy, the platforms, and what you did not do

RESPOND is not a checklist to complete in order. Immediate danger or possible risk to life: act first (999 when needed, stay with the child, summon the DSL or a deputy), then return to the steps.

Need the essentials? The *Quick Reference Card* at the end of this guide covers the immediate response and escalation on one page.

The One Chance Rule: a disclosure may be a young person's only attempt to seek help. Make it count.

The RESPOND Helix: How the Steps Move

RESPOND is taught in a line, Recognise to Document, because sequence gives structure under pressure. In practice it moves as a helix. The first dimension is the steps themselves: you may

loop back, hold at a step, or go straight to Notify. The second is time and severity: each turn sits higher as a concern develops. The third is context: a concern involving several children, places or platforms traces a wider spiral.

Relational and Systemic

For a child, safeguarding is **relational**: it happens through people they trust. For the adults around them, it is also **systemic**: the steps, records and shared decisions that make sure what a child tells one person reaches the people who can help.

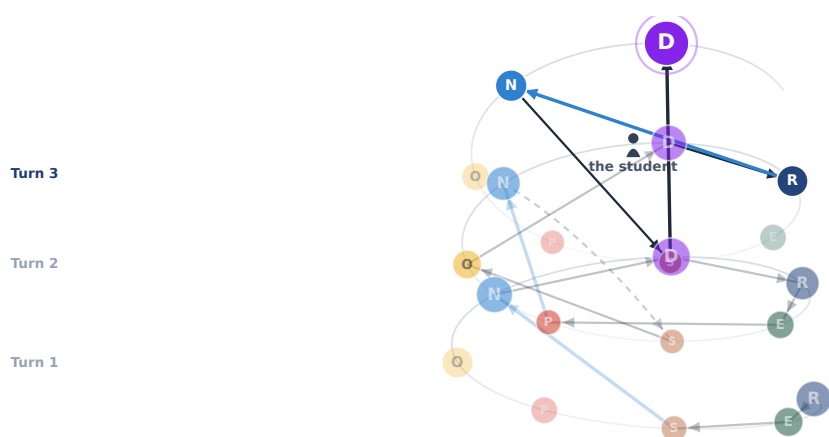
Relational is why children tell. Systemic is why telling works.

The RESPOND steps follow the same shape: Recognise, Engage and Support are relational; Pause is the bridge; Offer, Notify and Document are the systems steps. Neither works alone. Relationship without the system becomes secrecy, which is why staff never promise to keep a disclosure to themselves. The system without relationship becomes process that children do not trust enough to use. When you share information, be open with the child about what you are sharing and why.

See It Move

One example: a Year 9 student and an online "mentor", over six weeks, from small changes to a planned meeting. Then see what happens when steps are skipped.

This is a still image of the interactive RESPOND Helix. Open the web version of this guide to step through the examples; every example is also written out in full below.



▼ Read the helix demonstration as text

Sequence

How RESPOND is taught.

1. **The seven steps:** RESPOND is taught in this order, Recognise to Document, because sequence gives structure under pressure. Recognise, Engage and Support are the relational steps; Pause is the bridge; Offer, Notify and Document are the systems steps.
2. **But practice is not a line:** Grooming builds over weeks or months, and each sign can look harmless. When a meeting is planned or images are asked for, you go straight to Notify. Choose an example to see how the steps move.

An online "mentor"

A Year 9 student is befriended online by an older "mentor" over six weeks. The helix wraps around the student.

1. **Turn 1: small changes:** A form tutor notices a Year 9 student has expensive new headphones, is on her phone at every break, and has stopped sitting with her friends. Recognise: use the 4 Ps. You don't need proof.
2. **Turn 1:** Engage: "Tell me how things are going at the moment." She mentions "a new friend online who gets me". Stay warm; don't interrogate or criticise the friend.
3. **Turn 1:** Support: tell her she can always come to you, including about things online that feel confusing.
4. **Turn 1:** Notify: the DSL, the same day. An older online friend, gifts and dropped friendships together are a recognised pattern, and the DSL may hold other pieces.
5. **Turn 1:** Document: GOLD. What you saw, what she said, in her words, and what you did.
6. **Turn 2: the secret (three weeks later):** Her friend tells a teacher: the "mentor" is an adult, sends her money for games, and has told her not to tell her parents. They now talk on a private app.
7. **Turn 2:** Engage: thank the friend, and don't ask them to find out more. The student defends him: "He's the only one who listens." Don't argue. Use the script: "I believe you, and I'm taking what you've told me seriously. This is not your fault. I'm going to help keep you safe, and I'll explain what happens next."
8. **Turn 2: hold:** Pause for 90 seconds, then Three Lenses. Hold here on purpose: don't message the account, search her phone, or tell her to block him today. That could alert him and lose evidence.
9. **Turn 2: N before O:** Notify: the DSL, the same day, in person. The DSL decides about the police, evidence and parents, and in what order.
10. **Turn 2: loop back:** Support: she is not in trouble. She may feel protective of him, and ashamed; both are common, and neither is a reason to wait.
1. **Turn 2:** Offer, once the DSL is involved: model what a safe adult looks like. Safe adults don't ask you to keep secrets from your family or give gifts with strings attached. Explain what happens next.
2. **Turn 2:** Document: GOLD, as soon as is practicably possible: her words and her friend's, the gifts, the private app.
3. **Turn 3: a meeting (a week later):** She tells a house parent he has offered to pay for a train ticket to meet him on Saturday. A planned meeting is urgent.
4. **Turn 3: straight to Notify:** Notify: the DSL immediately, including the on-call DSL out of hours; 999 if she may be in immediate danger. Because earlier concerns were recorded, the DSL sees the whole pattern.
5. **Turn 3:** Support: stay with her. She may be angry, frightened of losing him, or relieved. "You haven't done anything wrong."
6. **Turn 3:** Document: GOLD, linked to the earlier records, so the chronology is visible.

When it breaks

The same Year 9 student and the online "mentor", when steps are skipped.

1. **Turn 1:** A teacher notices the gifts, the secrecy and the older online friend. Recognise happens.
2. **Support skipped:** The teacher says, "You shouldn't talk to strangers. Block him." She hears that she is in trouble.
3. **Pause skipped:** The teacher messages the account to warn him off. Pause is skipped: he tells her to delete their chats and moves to a new account.
4. **Notify and Document skipped:** Nothing reaches the DSL, and nothing is recorded. When her friend raises a worry weeks later, there is nothing to connect it to.
5. **The helix fragments:** The contact continues, hidden, and his message that adults can't be trusted has been proved right. That is how harm escalates unseen.
6. **Put it back together:** Every step taken puts the structure back. Relational is why children tell; systemic is why telling works.

The Helix is described in the RESPOND Safeguarding Operating System (section 5.2). All examples are fictional.

R

RECOGNISE: Notice the Pattern

Grooming is built from small steps, and each can look harmless on its own. Your job is to notice, and to pass on what you notice. The pattern helps explain; it is never a threshold. You don't need certainty to act.

The 4 Ps Context Scan

People

Is there a new, older friend, a "mentor" or a partner? An adult who gives this child special attention? A peer introducing them to older people?

Places

Games, clubs, lifts, the school gate, parks, shops, parties, other people's homes, the boarding house

Platforms

Online games and voice chat, social media, a move to a private or encrypted app, new accounts or a second phone

Patterns

Gifts, secrecy, dropping friends, going missing, late-night phone use. Is it speeding up?

Three Kinds of Grooming, Three Pathways

The same process can serve different ends, sometimes more than one (KCSIE 2026, paragraph 38 and Annex B). You notice and tell; the DSL decides the pathway.

Grooming for	What it can look like	Pathway (the DSL decides)
Sexual abuse or exploitation	Flattery, a "special" relationship, escalating sexual talk, requests for images or to meet	Children's social care and police; CEOP for online sexual abuse; UKCIS if images are involved
Criminal exploitation	Gifts, money, status or protection, then "favours" and debts; going missing	Children's social care and police; a National Referral Mechanism referral (KCSIE 2026, paragraph 38)
Radicalisation	Belonging and purpose offered by a person or group; "us and them" thinking; secret new contacts	The DSL follows the Prevent process, which can lead to Channel support (Prevent duty guidance for DSLs)

How Grooming Develops

Grooming often follows recognisable steps, not always in this order, and sometimes quickly (NSPCC Learning).

Trust and a "Special" Relationship

- Attention, flattery and understanding: "You're so mature." "I'm the only one who really gets you."
- Presenting as a mentor, a boyfriend or girlfriend, a talent scout, or someone the same age

Gifts and Favours

- Gifts, money, gaming credit, phones, lifts, food, alcohol or vapes
- Favours that later become debts: "After everything I've done for you..."

Secrecy and Isolation

- "Don't tell your parents." Secrets that feel exciting at first, then frightening
- Criticising friends and family, and encouraging the child to pull away from them

Testing Boundaries and Moving Out of Sight

- Jokes, touch or sexual talk that go a little further each time, to see how the child reacts
- Moving from a game or public platform to a private or encrypted messaging app
- Asking for images, then using them as leverage; suggesting a meeting

Signs You Might Notice in a Student

- Unexplained gifts, money, new clothes, a new phone or gaming credit, big or small
- Secrecy about who they are talking to or where they go; hiding their screen; a second phone
- A friendship or relationship with a much older person; talk of a "boyfriend", "girlfriend" or "mentor" no one has met
- Withdrawing from friends and family; changes in mood; seeming upset, anxious or distracted
- Much more or less time online; tiredness; going missing, or being picked up by unknown adults
- Sexual language you wouldn't expect for their age; alcohol or drug use; new views that echo someone else's language

Signs drawn from NSPCC Learning and KCSIE 2026, Annex B (unexplained gifts, money or new possessions can indicate criminal and sexual exploitation). Any one sign can have an innocent explanation; several together, or a change over time, needs passing on.

Who Grooms

- **Adults online**, sometimes posing as young people, and **adults the child knows**: family friends, coaches, tutors, faith leaders, and people who work or volunteer with children, including school staff.
- **Other young people**. The age gap can be small (NSPCC Learning). Some children recruit or introduce other children for adults, often while being exploited themselves; KCSIE 2026 says the child perpetrator should also be recognised as a victim (Annex B). They still need a safeguarding response, and the behaviour still needs to stop.

- Men and women, individuals, groups and organised networks can all groom children (KCSIE 2026, paragraph 44 and Annex B).

No Disclosure Needed

Children who are being groomed often **don't know it**, and may believe they are in a caring relationship (NSPCC Learning). They may feel ashamed, afraid of getting the person into trouble, or afraid of losing their phone. If you notice the signs, pass them to the DSL **without waiting for a disclosure**, and record what you saw and heard, factually.

What the Law Says (England and Wales)

- **Grooming is a safeguarding concern at any age**, whether or not a crime can be proved.
- **Sexual communication with a child:** an offence for a person aged 18 or over to intentionally communicate with a child under 16, for sexual gratification, where the communication is sexual or is meant to encourage the child to make a sexual communication, and they do not reasonably believe the child is 16 or over (Sexual Offences Act 2003, section 15A).
- **Meeting a child following sexual grooming:** an offence for a person aged 18 or over who has met or communicated with a child under 16 on at least one earlier occasion, and then meets them, travels to meet them or arranges to meet them, intending to commit a sexual offence (section 15).
- **Positions of trust:** it is an offence for a person aged 18 or over in a position of trust, which includes people working in a school where the child is a student, to engage in sexual activity with a child under 18, even if the child is 16 or 17 and the relationship appears consensual (section 16; KCSIE 2026, footnote to paragraph 123). Since 2022 this also covers adults who regularly coach, teach, train, supervise or instruct a child in sport or religion (section 22A).
- **16 and 17 year olds:** the two grooming offences protect children under 16, but grooming and exploitation of 16 and 17 year olds is still abuse, and other offences may apply (KCSIE 2026, paragraph 44).
- **Images** of anyone under 18 that are nude or sexual, including AI-generated ones, involve criminal offences; schools follow the UKCIS advice.
- **Children who groom others:** criminal responsibility starts at 10 (GOV.UK), but a child recruiting others for adults may be being exploited themselves, and is then recognised as a victim too (Annex B).

Staff should not decide whether an offence has been committed. Describe what you saw and heard, and report it to the DSL. Legal references checked 28 September 2026.

What the Data Shows

7,263

sexual communication with a child offences recorded by 44 UK police forces in the most recent year reported

NSPCC, 2025

Almost 2x

the number in 2017/18, the first year of the offence, where forces could be compared

NSPCC, 2025

80%

of children targeted were girls, where gender was known. Boys are targeted too

NSPCC, 2025

Figures obtained by the NSPCC from 44 UK police forces (7,062 offences from 45 forces in 2023/24: NSPCC, 2024). They show recorded crime, not how common grooming is: the NSPCC notes the real number is likely to be much higher. Checked 28 September 2026.

E

ENGAGE: Stay Curious, Stay Warm

Your first response decides whether the student keeps talking to you. The groomer has probably told them adults won't understand. Prove them wrong: stay calm, don't criticise the person, and use TED questions, never "why".

What a Student Might Say

"It's not a big deal. He's just a friend from a game. He's older but he really gets me, and he buys me stuff. Please don't tell my mum, she'll take my phone."

The **RESPOND** disclosure script:

"I believe you, and I'm taking what you've told me seriously. This is not your fault. I'm going to help keep you safe, and I'll explain what happens next."

- **Thank them:** "Thank you for telling me. I'm really glad you did."
- **TED:** "Tell me about this friend." "Explain how you started talking." "Describe what you talk about now." Never "why": "Why did you send that?" sounds like blame.
- **Ask what you need for safety:** "Has he asked to meet you?" "Has he asked you for any photos?" "Has anyone asked you to keep this secret?"
- **Don't criticise the person.** "He sounds dodgy" can make the student defend him and stop talking. Focus on the behaviour: "Asking you to keep secrets from your family isn't OK."
- **Look only at what they choose to show you.** Don't take or scroll through the phone. If anything sexual appears, look away and stop.

Helpful

- "You're not in trouble."
- "A safe adult wouldn't ask you to keep secrets from your family."
- "None of this is your fault, whatever has happened."

Unhelpful

- "How could you be so naive?" (shame, and it closes the conversation)
- "You shouldn't talk to strangers online." (blame; he may not feel like a stranger to her)
- "Just block him" or "I'll message him." (can alert him; see Pause)

If a Friend Tells You

"I'm worried about my friend. She's talking to this older guy online and he keeps sending her money. She made me promise not to tell."

- **Thank them:** "You've done the right thing. Being a good friend sometimes means telling."
- **TED:** "Tell me what you've noticed." "Describe what she's told you."
- **Don't ask them to find out more,** look at messages, screenshot anything, contact the person, or keep watch. Tell them you will pass it on carefully.

If You See Something Now

If an unknown adult is waiting for a student or offering a lift near school, act **if it is safe to do so**, using the 4Ds: **Direct** ("Can I help you?"), **Distract** (give the student a reason to come inside with you), **Delegate** (get a colleague or the DSL), **Delay** (check in with the student afterwards). Don't mention grooming to the adult. Note what you saw, including any vehicle, and tell the DSL straight away; 999 if a child is in immediate danger.



SUPPORT: Safety First

Safety comes first: is a meeting planned, have images been asked for or shared, and is the student safe today and tonight? Your calm is contagious.

Safety Check Questions

Meeting

- "Have you met him, or made a plan to meet?"

Images

- "Has anyone asked you for photos or videos?"
- "Has anyone threatened to share something?"

Digital

- "Does he know where you live or go to school? Can he see your location?"
- "Does he know you've talked to me?"

Today and Tonight

- "How are you getting home?" "Are you expecting to hear from him tonight?"

If a Meeting Is Planned or Images Are Involved

Tell the DSL immediately, in person, and keep the student with a trusted adult. If a meeting is happening now or the student has gone missing, **call 999**.

They May Not See Themselves as a Victim

- They may feel **loyal to, protective of, or in love with** the person. Arguing about him usually pushes them closer to him.

- They may feel ashamed, stupid or responsible, especially if they accepted gifts, sent images or lied to their family. Say clearly that it is not their fault.
- They may fear losing their phone, their friends or their freedom. Where you can, reassure them honestly that telling is not a punishment.
- They may be angry with you. Keep the door open: "I'm still here, whenever you want to talk."

Immediate Practical Support

- A private, quiet space; water; time; the option not to go straight back to lessons
- Ask them not to delete anything and not to tell the person they have spoken to you
- Don't take their phone as a punishment; the DSL decides if a device is secured for evidence

SEND, Neurodivergence and Language

- Allow extra processing time and a quiet space. Use clear, concrete language; avoid idioms and double questions.
- Some students may find it harder to recognise manipulation or explain what has happened (KCSIE 2026, paragraph 249).
- Involve the SENCO alongside the DSL (paragraph 250).
- Use a professional interpreter where language is a barrier, never another student or a family member.
- Record any adjustments you made.

Support for Other Students Involved

Friends who told need thanks and reassurance, even though they broke a promise, and a check on whether they have been contacted too. **A student who introduced others** needs a safeguarding response, as they may be exploited themselves, with clear boundaries planned by the DSL.



PAUSE: Consider Your Approach

Act with composure. Take 90 seconds: breathe, lower your shoulders, check your own state. The urge to protect the child by confronting the person, or grabbing the phone, is strong. Pause is where you stop.

Three Lenses

Lens	In this scenario
Risk	Is a meeting planned? Have images been asked for or shared? Does the person know where the student is? Could a staff member or family member be involved? Are other students targeted?
Rights	The student's right to be safe, believed and heard, and to have a say in the plan, even while they defend the person; other children's right to be protected
Resources	The DSL, pastoral and counselling staff, the SENCO, the police, CEOP, children's social care, and the safe adults in the student's life

What You Must Not Do

Don't Alert or Confront the Suspected Groomer

- Don't message the account, call the person, or speak to them at the school gate
- Don't ask the student to tell them to stop, or to block them today
- It can put the child at greater risk and lead to evidence being deleted

Don't Investigate

- Don't search the student's phone, social media or games, or look up the person online

Evidence: the DSL Decides

- **Never view, copy, forward or delete a nude or semi-nude image** of a young person, even as evidence (UKCIS)
- Don't photograph the screen, or ask the student to forward messages to you
- Ask the student not to delete anything. The DSL decides how evidence is preserved, often with the police

- Students are never asked to collect evidence

Don't Promise Secrecy

"I'm really glad you told me. I can't keep this to myself, because I'm worried about your safety. I'll need to speak to the DSL, whose job is to help keep you safe. I'll only share it with people who need to know, and I'll tell you what's happening."

Check Your Own Response

- **If the concern is about a colleague or volunteer**, notice any pull to explain it away ("They'd never..."). Groomers build trust with adults too. Report it anyway (see Notify).
- If you feel overwhelmed: "This is important and I want to get it right. Can you wait here with [colleague] while I speak to the DSL?"
- Afterwards, look after yourself. Talk to the DSL or your line manager. Education Support: 08000 562 561, free, confidential, 24/7, for education staff.



OFFER: Model Alternatives

Offer proportionate options without coercion, explain what happens next, and model what a safe relationship with an adult looks like. If in doubt, N before O: tell the DSL before offering options.

Explain What Happens Next

"Here's what happens now. I'm going to speak to our safeguarding lead today, whose job is to keep you safe, and I can be there when they talk with you. Please don't delete anything, and don't tell him you've spoken to us; that keeps you safe, it doesn't get you into trouble. They may talk to the police, and will think carefully about how your parents are told. What questions do you have?"

Be honest about information sharing. Staff should share safeguarding information as early as possible, and data protection law does not prevent it; safeguarding children is a lawful basis for sharing sensitive information without consent where appropriate (KCSIE 2026, paragraphs 142 to 148). What is shared must be relevant, necessary and proportionate, go only to those who need it, and be handled in line with data protection law. From 30 September 2026, the Information Sharing Duty (section 16LA,

Children Act 2004) also requires the organisations it covers to share where its tests are met; the DSL decides how it applies. So don't ask for consent as if it were the legal basis. Tell the student what will be shared, with whom and why, unless that would increase the risk, and listen to their views: they shape the plan. Agreeing to a service, such as counselling, is a separate question, and their agreement matters there.

Options, Not Orders

- "Would you like me to stay while you talk to the DSL?"
- "Who at school do you feel safest talking to?"

Some things have to happen to keep them safe, such as telling the DSL. Where there is a choice, give it to them.

Model the Alternative

Safe Adults

- Are people you could talk about with a trusted adult of your choice, at school, in boarding or outside the family
- Keep conversations open, not secret
- Respect your age and your boundaries
- Don't give gifts that come with strings

Warning Signs

- "Keep this between us."
- Moving chats to a private app
- Gifts, then favours or debts
- Asking for photos, or to meet

Use the student's own words. The difference between a safe relationship and a grooming one belongs in the RSHE curriculum for everyone, not only for the students involved: the RSHE statutory guidance expects students to learn the law on online sexual abuse, including grooming, and about grooming into criminal activity.

Support in School and Beyond

- Counselling or pastoral mentoring; a regular check-in with a named adult
- The tutor made aware (without details) so they can support
- Help to reconnect with friends and activities; Childline and CEOP (see Additional Resources)

N NOTIFY: Report the Concern

Tell the DSL as soon as is practicably possible, and the same day. Where a meeting is planned, images are involved or there is immediate risk, tell them immediately. If a child is in immediate danger, call 999.

Who and When

- Find the DSL in person if you can: "I need to speak to you today about a possible grooming concern."
- If the DSL is not available, go to a deputy. If neither can be reached, go to a senior leader, or take advice from children's social care (KCSIE 2026, paragraph 61). Don't wait until the end of the day.
- Anyone can refer directly to children's social care if they believe a child is at risk; telling the DSL does not remove your own responsibility.

If the Concern Is About a Member of Staff, Volunteer or Contractor

- **Report it to the headteacher**, who will consider whether to refer to the LADO. If it is about the headteacher, report it to the chair of governors or the proprietor. If the headteacher is also the sole proprietor, or there is a conflict of interest, report it directly to the LADO (KCSIE 2026, paragraph 78; Part four).
- This includes supply staff, trainee teachers, volunteers and contractors, and conduct outside school (paragraphs 437 and 438).
- **Smaller worries still matter.** Being overfriendly, having favourites, or seeing a student one-to-one behind a closed door can be "low-level concerns" (paragraph 509): share them under the low-level concerns policy (paragraph 79). Report private messaging with students outside agreed channels too: the staff behaviour policy covers staff and student communications, including social media (paragraph 123).
- **Don't tell the colleague**, and don't investigate. If there is immediate risk to a child, tell the DSL as well, straight away.

- If you feel unable to raise it internally, or it is not being addressed: NSPCC Whistleblowing Advice Line: 0800 028 0285 (Monday to Friday 8am to 8pm; weekends 9am to 6pm), for staff worried about how their organisation is handling a child protection concern (NSPCC; KCSIE 2026, paragraph 82).

What to Tell the DSL

- Who the student is, where they are now, and who is with them
- What you saw or were told, in the student's words (and the words of any friend who told you)
- What you know about the person: name or username, platform, age as described, any link to school
- Gifts, money or favours; requests for secrecy; any move to a private app
- Whether a meeting is planned, images have been asked for or shared, or threats made
- Whether other students may be involved; what you have said and done so far

▼ For the DSL: assessment, external agencies and parents

Most staff need only: tell the DSL, today, with the information above.

The DSL's Initial Actions

- Assess immediate risk: a planned meeting, images, threats, going missing, or contact with the child tonight. If a child may be in immediate danger, call 999
- Follow the pathway for each kind of grooming involved (see Recognise): children's social care and the police; the National Referral Mechanism for exploitation; Prevent for radicalisation
- Where the suspected groomer works or volunteers with children anywhere, including outside school, involve the LADO, who oversees allegations against adults working with children in a paid or voluntary capacity (Working Together 2026, paragraph 262). If it is a member of the school's staff, the headteacher leads under Part four
- Decide how evidence is preserved, with the police where they are involved, never copying intimate images, following UKCIS
- Consider other children: friends who have been contacted, and peers who introduced the student
- Where the police are involved, agree with them what is said to other families, and when, before any contact

- Where the Information Sharing Duty applies (from 30 September 2026), apply its three tests: share information that is relevant to safeguarding or promoting the child's welfare (Relevance) and may help the recipient to safeguard or promote their welfare (May facilitate), unless sharing would be more detrimental to the child than not sharing (Detriment), which applies only in extremely limited circumstances; record the decision to share or not share, with the rationale, and be transparent with the young person unless that would increase the risk. Data protection law still applies to how information is shared
- Record on the safeguarding system, with a chronology, and set review dates

When to Involve Other Agencies

Agency	When
Police (999 or 101)	A planned meeting; sexual communication with a child; images; threats; criminal exploitation; any immediate danger; to preserve evidence
Children's social care	Significant harm or risk of it; exploitation; concerns at home
LADO	The suspected groomer works or volunteers with children, in or out of school
CEOP (National Crime Agency)	Online sexual abuse or grooming. CEOP says professionals who have already reported to the police or children's social care do not also need to report to CEOP (CEOP). Not for bullying, fake accounts or hacking
Prevent	Grooming towards extremist views or groups, following local referral arrangements

Where a Student Is 18

At 18 a student is legally an adult. The child safeguarding framework in KCSIE applies to under-18s, but the school still has welfare responsibilities. Where an 18-year-old is involved, the DSL considers adult safeguarding, police and welfare pathways alongside the school's procedures, and the adult student's own views and consent in a different way. This matters in sixth form and in boarding, where students turn 18 during their final year.

Before Contacting Parents or Carers

Parents are usually told, and are often key to keeping the child safe. First assess whether contact could increase the risk: a family member or family friend may be involved, a parent may confront and alert the person, or the child may face harm at home. Where it could, take advice from children's social care or the police first. The school has no power to keep a child from a parent; only the police or a court can. If there is immediate risk, call 999.

Parent contact: the student being groomed

- "We need to talk to you about [name]. We're worried that an older person has been contacting them and giving them gifts, and has asked them to keep it secret. [Name] is safe and has done nothing wrong."
- "Please don't contact this person, post about it, or take [name]'s phone and delete anything. We're working with [the police / children's social care] and will agree next steps with you. Have you noticed any changes at home?"

Parent contact: a student who introduced others

- "We're concerned [name] may have introduced other students to an older person, and worried [name] may be being exploited too. Please keep [name]'s phone as it is, and don't contact anyone, until we've agreed next steps."

D DOCUMENT: Record Observations

Record as soon as is practicably possible, on the school's safeguarding system, using **GOLD**. Grooming is often only visible across several records, so each small observation matters, and your record may be used by the police.

GOLD

Ground

Date, time, place, who was present, who you are, and how it came to your attention

Observe

What you saw and heard, with exact words in quotation marks

Language

Neutral, factual and non-diagnostic. No opinions or labels

Do

What you did, what you said would happen next, and why

Example: Exact Words and What You Saw

- Student said: "He's just a friend from a game. He's older but he gets me."
- Student said: "He told me not to tell my mum because she wouldn't understand."
- Student's friend said: "He keeps sending her money for games, and now they talk on a different app."
- Observed over three weeks: new headphones; on her phone at every break; no longer sitting with her friends.

Recording template

SAFEGUARDING CONCERN: POSSIBLE GROOMING

Date and time:

Student: name, year, tutor group

Recorded by: name and role

Where and how it came to your attention:

WHAT THE STUDENT (OR FRIEND) SAID (exact words in quotation marks):

WHAT I OBSERVED (and over what period):

THE PERSON (as described): name or username, platform(s), age, how they met, any link to school

GIFTS, MONEY OR FAVOURS:

SECRECY OR ISOLATION:

MOVE TO PRIVATE PLATFORMS:

MEETING PLANNED? IMAGES ASKED FOR OR SHARED? THREATS? yes / no / details
(never copy or describe an image)

OTHER STUDENTS WHO MAY BE INVOLVED:

WHAT I DID AND SAID (with times), and what I did NOT do (no contact with the person, no phone search, no copies):

SHARED WITH: DSL (name, time, how)

THE STUDENT'S WISHES AND VIEWS:

Signed and dated:

What Not to Record

- Your opinions about the student's judgement, or about the family
- Content of any intimate image. Record that one was mentioned or appeared; never copy, attach or describe it



Online Grooming

For many young people, online friendships are real friendships. Respond to the behaviour, not to the fact that the friend is online.

- **Games and group platforms** are common first points of contact. Groomers then often move the child to a private or encrypted messaging app, where contact is harder to see (NSPCC Learning).
- **Fake identities:** adults may pose as children or young adults (KCSIE 2026, paragraph 165).
- **Images:** requests for images can quickly become threats and blackmail; follow UKCIS (see Pause). Report Remove (Childline and the Internet Watch Foundation): helps under-18s get a nude or sexual image of themselves removed online, at childline.org.uk.
- **Online and offline are one life:** abuse often happens in both at once (KCSIE 2026, paragraph 22).



Boarding and Residential Life

For boarders, school is also home. A boarder who is lonely or far from family may welcome special attention, and much contact happens on the phone at night.

Step	In boarding
● Recognise	Use the 4 Ps for the house: late-night phone use, parcels, leave-out and exeat plans, lifts from unknown adults, and visitors or older students giving one boarder special attention.
● Engage	Boarders often tell house staff late in the evening. Use TED and the script, in a visible space.
● Support	Safety tonight comes first: is contact expected tonight, or a meeting at the weekend? The DSL plans supervision, leave-out and any change to phone arrangements; don't take a phone as a punishment.
● Pause	Other boarders may be in contact with the same person. Don't search rooms or phones. If the concern is about boarding staff, follow the allegations route.
● Offer	Model alternatives: house expectations about online friendships, gifts and visitors. If in doubt, N before O.
● Notify	The on-call DSL immediately where there may be immediate risk, including at night. Immediate danger: 999. Out of hours, the local authority's emergency duty team can advise.

Step

In boarding

- Record on the safeguarding system before you go off duty, using GOLD. A house log or handover note is not a substitute.

Document

Boarders' Routes to Help

- **Boarders can always contact their house parents, the DSL or a member of the boarding management team, at any time, day or night.** Make sure every boarder knows how.
- An independent person outside the staff whom boarders can contact directly (NMS 11.4), often called the independent listener
- Boarders must be able to contact their families privately; monitoring of communications should be proportionate (NMS 12.1)
- International boarders: agree with the DSL who contacts parents or guardians, when, and in what language, using interpreters where needed

Source: National Minimum Standards for Boarding Schools (2026).

International boarders may be targeted by people offering help, money or a sense of home. Include guardians, host families and holidays in the 4 Ps.

Vulnerability and Intersecting Harm

Any child can be groomed; groomers look for a need they can meet. The NSPCC lists groups who may be particularly vulnerable, including looked after children and children known to social care, children exploring their sexuality and identity online, children with SEND, and children with low self-esteem (NSPCC Learning). Each is a reason to notice, not to treat a child as a problem.

- **SEND:** communication barriers, and assuming changes in behaviour are due to the child's needs, can make abuse harder to recognise (KCSIE 2026, paragraph 249); DSLs should recognise the additional risks of grooming online for children with SEND (Annex C).
- **Care-experienced students:** looked after and previously looked after children are a particularly vulnerable group, and agencies need to act promptly together (KCSIE 2026, paragraph 238). The DSL involves the designated teacher and social worker.
- **LGBTQ+ students:** being lesbian, gay or bisexual is not in itself a risk factor for harm (KCSIE 2026, paragraph 253). But a young person seeking connection online, before they feel able to talk to anyone at home or school, may be targeted by someone offering it. Don't "out" a student; the DSL considers this when planning parent contact. For under-18s: Galop Children and Young People's Service (LGBT+ young people aged 13 to 25): if you are under 18, use the online referral form at galop.org.uk/make-a-referral, or call Childline on 0800 1111.

- **Boys** are groomed too, and may be less likely to tell. Girls are at risk of criminal exploitation too (KCSIE 2026, paragraph 41).

Additional Resources and Support

For Students

- Childline (for anyone under 19): 0800 1111, free and confidential; call any time, day or night, or use 1-2-1 chat at [childline.org.uk](https://www.childline.org.uk) (you may have to wait for a chat counsellor, so calling is usually quickest). **For under-18s, this is the place to start.**
- CEOP Safety Centre (National Crime Agency): ceop.police.uk, for reporting online sexual abuse, or worries about the way someone has been communicating with a child online. It cannot deal with bullying, fake accounts or hacking
- Shout: text **SHOUT** to 85258, free, confidential, 24/7
- Childline, *Grooming and online grooming*

For Parents and Carers

- NSPCC Helpline: 0808 800 5000 (Monday to Friday 10am to 4pm), or help@nspcc.org.uk
- CEOP Education (National Crime Agency): ceopeducation.co.uk/parents, advice for parents on grooming, conversation starters and parental controls
- YoungMinds Parents Helpline: 0808 802 5544 (Monday, Thursday and Friday 9:30am to 4pm; Tuesday and Wednesday 9:30am to 6pm)

For Staff

- Education Support: 08000 562 561, free, confidential, 24/7, for education staff
- NSPCC Whistleblowing Advice Line: 0800 028 0285 (Monday to Friday 8am to 8pm; weekends 9am to 6pm), for staff worried about how their organisation is handling a child protection concern
- NSPCC Learning, *Grooming: recognising the signs*
- National Crime Agency, *CEOP Safety Centre: should I make a report? (concerned adults)*

Statutory Guidance and Law

- Department for Education, *Keeping Children Safe in Education 2026*
- HM Government, *Working Together to Safeguard Children 2026*
- Department for Education, *Information Sharing Duty: statutory guidance* (in force 30 September 2026)
- Department for Education, *RSHE statutory guidance* (published July 2025; statutory from September 2026)
- Department for Education, *National minimum standards for boarding schools* (2026)
- UKCIS, *Sharing nudes and semi-nudes: advice for education settings*
- Department for Education, *The Prevent duty: practical guidance for designated safeguarding leads* (updated 24 September 2026)
- Sexual Offences Act 2003, section 15A (sexual communication with a child)
- Sexual Offences Act 2003, section 15 (meeting a child following sexual grooming etc.)
- Sexual Offences Act 2003, section 16 (abuse of position of trust)
- Sexual Offences Act 2003, section 22A (positions of trust in sport and religion)
- GOV.UK, *Age of criminal responsibility*

Figures

- NSPCC, *Data shows how criminals are using private messaging platforms to manipulate and groom children* (13 November 2025)
- NSPCC, *Online grooming crimes against children increase by 89% in six years* (1 November 2024)

Contacts, figures and legal references checked 28 September 2026. Verify at point of use.



Quick Reference Card

Immediate Danger Comes First

Immediate danger or possible risk to life: call 999 when it is needed, stay with the child, and summon the DSL or a deputy. Don't delay action to work through the steps. The 90-second Pause is for once immediate safety is secured, to stop an impulsive or investigative response.

Recognise

- Gifts, secrecy, an older "special" friend, isolation from friends
- A move to private apps; talk of meeting; requests for images
- Sexual, criminal or radicalisation grooming: you don't need to know which
- No disclosure needed, and no need to wait for it to happen again

Respond

- "I believe you, and I'm taking what you've told me seriously. This is not your fault."
- TED, never "why"; don't criticise the person
- Never alert or confront the suspected groomer
- Don't promise secrecy, investigate, or search the phone

Notify

- DSL, the same day; immediately if a meeting or images are involved
- Immediate danger: 999
- About a member of staff or volunteer: the headteacher (the chair or proprietor if about the head)
- If in doubt, N before O

Document

- GOLD: Ground, Observe, Language, Do
- Their words; gifts, secrecy, platforms, dates
- No copies, and never describe an image

Key Numbers

- Emergency: 999; police non-emergency: 101
- Childline (for anyone under 19): 0800 1111, free and confidential; call any time, day or night, or use 1-2-1 chat at [childline.org.uk](https://www.childline.org.uk) (you may have to wait for a chat counsellor, so calling is usually quickest)
- CEOP Safety Centre (National Crime Agency): [ceop.police.uk](https://www.ceop.police.uk), for reporting online sexual abuse, or worries about the way someone has been communicating with a child online. It cannot deal with bullying, fake accounts or hacking
- Your DSL: named in the school's safeguarding policy

Online Evidence: One Rule

- **Ordinary messages or posts a student has already shown you:** note what is relevant (platform, date, who, exact words) in your record. Don't ask to see more or scroll through a phone, especially where messages may be sexual, because they may contain images. Don't log in to accounts, search profiles or investigate, and never transfer anything to a personal device.
- **Nude or semi-nude images of anyone under 18:** don't intentionally view, copy, screenshot, forward, save or delete them. Tell the DSL straight away. If you see one by accident, tell the DSL, ask for support if you need it, and record that it was seen and what you did, without describing the image (UKCIS).
- The DSL decides what happens to devices and content.

Your School's Contacts

This guide is generic. Schools add their own details here, or keep a completed copy with this card, so that anyone responding, including at night, has the routes to hand.

Contact	Name and how to reach them
Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL)	
Deputy DSL(s)	
Out-of-hours and boarding on-call safeguarding contact	
How to record a concern (system or form)	
Local authority children's services front door	
Out-of-hours emergency duty team	
LADO (concerns about adults)	
Police: 999 (emergency); 101 (non-emergency)	

RESPOND Safeguarding Framework Reference Scenarios · Staff Guide 31

Scenario 31: Signs of Grooming

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Aligned with: KCSIE 2026 | Working Together to Safeguard Children 2026 | Information Sharing Duty (September 2026) | Sexual Offences Act 2003 | RSHE statutory guidance (published July 2025; statutory from September 2026) | NMS for Boarding Schools 2026 | UKCIS sharing nudes and semi-nudes advice | Prevent duty guidance

Last Updated: September 2026 | Next Review: September 2027, or on publication of KCSIE 2027 if sooner

For staff in schools and other settings working with children. You may share it with colleagues. Share the student and parent guides, not this page, with students and families.